

Soft Trump voters: a fast ad program for the last five weeks

Whit Pendergast, Hoplight. Prepared September 23, 2026 for donor and experiment advisers.

One in five 2024 Trump voters now regret their vote, and the Iran war and rising costs top their reasons (Navigator Research, September 2026). Almost nobody is talking to them about it inside their own values, their own worldview, or a voice they would trust. This program does, with two betrayals they already feel: the Epstein files and the Iran war.

Low-cost static and motion ads on Meta, from a neutral or right-of-center name, to soft Trump voters, through November 3. A randomized message test first, then a random slice of the voter list held out so the effect on enthusiasm and turnout can be measured. Experiment advisers shape the measurement.

THREE PROGRAM SIZES

\$35K

Message test only

A randomized survey test among 2024 Trump voters, oversampling those who express regret. Epstein and Iran, two frames each, against a placebo. Measures enthusiasm to vote, approval and regret. Needs no vehicle. Starts on a yes. Results in about ten days.

Survey test vendor	\$24K
Test creative	\$3K
Hoplight: messages, copy, results memo	\$8K
Total	\$35K

\$180K

Test, then one state

The test above, then four weeks of ads in one Senate state or a set of House districts, with matched areas held out. About 6 to 8 million views, reaching roughly 650,000 to a million people eight to ten times each.

Ads on Meta	\$95K
Message test	\$24K
In-field measurement	\$25K
Creative, at cost	\$9K
Hoplight: messages, copy, ad operations, results memo	\$27K
Total	\$180K

\$475K

Test, then four states

The same run in four states or district sets, each with its own holdout, so the result replicates instead of resting on one place. About 2 to 3.5 million people reached.

Ads on Meta	\$340K
Message test	\$24K
In-field measurement	\$50K
Creative, at cost	\$16K
Hoplight: messages, copy, ad operations, results memo	\$45K
Total	\$475K

TIMELINE

On a yes	The message test goes to field. It needs no vehicle and no Meta approval. Results in about ten days.
By Oct 1	Funding committed and a vehicle named. That buys four weeks of live ads.
Oct 2 to 5	Winning messages built as statics and simple motion. First batch submitted to Meta review. Ads live October 5.
Oct 5 to 26	Three weekly rounds. Cut what is not working, move money to what is. Every variant loaded and running before Meta's cutoff for new political ads, about October 27 in past cycles.
Oct 27 to Nov 3	The money runs on the winners. Results memo by mid-November, once the turnout record is in.

WHAT IT NEEDS BESIDES MONEY

A neutral or right-of-center vehicle: an existing C4 or PAC with a brand, Meta's political ad approval already in hand, and an ad account with spending history. Ideally one that codes right or MAGA-aligned. Its counsel clears each ad against the public record. Hoplight operates the campaign and does not own the vehicle.

THE OPEN CHOICES

- **Where.** One Senate state, or a set of close House districts. The vehicle's owner may have a view. The budget fits either.
- **How it is measured.** Matched areas held out with a short survey in both, plus the turnout record afterward. If the vehicle already runs a texting program, person-level randomization against the voter file is cleaner and costs the same.
- **Which vehicle type.** A C4 works while the ads name only Trump, the Epstein files and the Iran war. An ad that names a 2026 candidate and urges their defeat moves the work to a PAC. Counsel decides.
- **A third issue.** Rising costs is the other top reason for regret. Adding it puts two more arms in the test, about \$6K to \$12K more, and a third creative set.
- **Added channels.** Volunteers sharing the same images, and text messages with images if the vehicle already texts. Both ride on the same creative at no added cost here.
- **Scale.** Money above the one-state size goes almost entirely to ads. The message test runs once at any size.

WHY HOPLIGHT

In a randomized trial of 3,006 US adults in August 2025, two messages produced by Hoplight's message generation tool were tested against a placebo and an existing campaign's persuasion message, on security officers' pay and their right to join a union.

- **Republicans:** agreement that the officers are underpaid went from 56 to 81 with the Hoplight frame. The staff-written message reached 70.
- **Enterprising conservatives:** 56 to 82 on pay, a 26-point lift. The staff-written message reached 63. **Religious conservatives:** support for the right to join a union went from 55 to 71. The staff-written message took it down to 51.
- **2024 non-voters:** pay agreement went from 44 to 66, and union support from 46 to 57. The staff-written message dropped union support to 36.

Separately, Whit Pendergast has run close to \$1 million of Meta ads for a commercial activist brand he co-founded, including ten months of Epstein-themed creative. Its 6.5 million views showed three things: Meta's review lets creative through when it implies, people stop for it as readily as anything else on the account, and the clicks cost 18 percent less.